

Canonical murder facts

- Sterling Voss dies from a fast-acting botanical cardiac toxin in his private cordial.
- The poison is introduced between 6:40 and 6:49 in the Donor Salon.
- The active murderer is not predetermined; one of the 15 core players becomes the murderer through the animal draw.
- Every core branch supplies a unique motive, access story, physical/timeline clue, and final confession.
- All fixed clues are compatible with all 15 murderer identities. Branch-dependent evidence is supplied from the player's own packet, so the facilitator never has to select the correct clue.
- Optional roles have full murderer branches for material symmetry, but standard play does not place them in the murderer draw.

Ominous but non-supernatural layer The 'curse' atmosphere is deliberately human-made or mundane. Imogen wrote the anonymous warning note as provocation. Riley's unauthorized lighting change causes the eerie flicker. Provenance gaps, the black-star archival seal, and the exhibition's morally charged objects create unease. Nothing supernatural causes Sterling's death.

01 / Adrian Vellum

Victim relationship: Sterling had privately informed you that tonight's gift would come with a new governance agreement: he wanted veto power over acquisitions, his name on the museum, and your resignation within sixty days. You smiled through the meeting and told no one.

Hidden complication: You have already accepted a confidential offer to lead a rival museum next year, which makes any argument with Sterling look like succession planning. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You entered the Donor Salon at 6:32 to replace Sterling's speech cards. At 6:40 you slipped into the museum office and took a confidential wired-landline call from the rival museum that has offered you a job; the call record runs continuously until 6:50. Revealing that record clears your timing but exposes your planned departure.

Murderer route: At 6:47 you returned to the Donor Salon under the pretense of correcting Sterling's speech cards. Furious at the takeover terms, you tipped the stolen toxin into his private cordial and wiped the stem with your pocket square. You left calmly and resumed hosting.

Innocent evidence / Card B: SPEECH CARDS - Adrian's handwritten speech cards were found beside Sterling's service tray. Adrian admits entering the Donor Salon earlier but insists he left before the critical window.

Murderer evidence / Card A: WITNESS TIMELINE - A catering assistant saw Adrian leaving the Donor Salon at 6:48. Adrian had claimed his only visit ended before 6:35.

02 / Celeste Frame

Victim relationship: You discovered that Sterling knew the Star Bowl's provenance file contained a major gap and ordered the exhibition to proceed anyway. He threatened to remove you from the show if you raised the issue publicly.

Hidden complication: Against board instructions, you commissioned an independent provenance review and hid the preliminary report in the Registrar's Office. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You were in the Donor Salon at 6:25 correcting an object label. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Registrar's scanner log shows your curator code repeatedly scanning the independent provenance report you were not authorized to commission. Revealing the log clears your timing but exposes the report.

Murderer route: At 6:44 you used a label correction as an excuse to enter the Donor Salon. Believing Sterling was about to lock dubious objects permanently into the museum, you poisoned his cordial and returned to the gallery before anyone noticed.

Innocent evidence / Card A: CURATOR'S PENCIL - Celeste's distinctive pencil was found beneath the edge of Sterling's service table. She says it was left during an earlier label correction.

Murderer evidence / Card B: CURATOR'S PENCIL - Celeste's pencil was found beneath Sterling's drink tray beside a handwritten time note: 'S.V. alone - 6:40.' She denied returning to the salon after 6:25.

03 / Grant Easel

Victim relationship: Sterling had learned that one certificate in a major private sale you brokered was forged before it ever reached you. He planned to imply publicly that you had created it unless you refunded him millions.

Hidden complication: You were duped on that sale, but you quietly altered your own file afterward so clients would not see how badly your due diligence failed. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You entered the Donor Salon at 6:34 to leave an appraisal folder and briefly handled a decorative decanter that looked like Sterling's service piece. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Media Room document terminal shows you revising and reprinting the disputed sale file you secretly altered. The audit trail clears your timing but exposes your cover-up.

Murderer route: At 6:43 you returned with a revised appraisal folder. You used the lookalike decanter as cover while slipping the toxin directly into Sterling's silver coupe, then wiped the stem before leaving.

Innocent evidence / Card B: DEALER'S CARD - Grant's business card was found beneath Sterling's appraisal folder in the Donor Salon. Grant admits delivering the folder shortly before the poisoning window.

Murderer evidence / Card A: SILVER COUPE - A partial print matching Grant survives beneath the wiped base of Sterling's silver coupe. Grant claimed he never touched Sterling's drink service.

04 / Margot Ledger

Victim relationship: Sterling demanded that you disguise several gala and naming-wing expenses inside restricted museum funds until his promised donation cleared. When you resisted, he threatened to blame the bookkeeping on you.

Hidden complication: You temporarily moved money between internal accounts to cover a cash-flow shortfall, intending to reverse it after the gala. It was technically unauthorized and Sterling discovered it. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You met Sterling at 6:33 for a signature. From 6:40 to 6:50, the finance terminal audit shows you reversing and re-entering the unauthorized internal transfer you were trying to hide. That audit trail clears your timing but exposes the accounting violation.

Murderer route: At 6:46 you returned to obtain the signature Sterling had withheld. When he mocked the accounting mess he had helped create, you poisoned his cordial. You then copied a budget sheet to create the impression your office visit happened earlier.

Innocent evidence / Card B: UNSIGNED BUDGET - Margot's corrected budget was found on Sterling's desk with a blank signature line. She admits she was seeking his signature shortly before he died.

Murderer evidence / Card A: COPIER LOG - Metadata shows Margot's '6:34' budget copy was actually printed at 6:49 after a manual clock reset. Her claimed timeline does not hold.

05 / Rafael Gilt

Victim relationship: Sterling pressured you to soften a conservation report showing that one supposedly untouched object had been recently altered. He threatened to replace you with a private conservator if you refused.

Hidden complication: You changed the date on a minor treatment record last month to spare the museum an embarrassing insurance dispute. No object was harmed, but the falsification could end your career. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You had legitimate access to the conservation cabinet. During the entire poison window, the Conservation Lab data logger records a sequence of manual humidity-calibration entries under your personal code at the case across the house. The log clears your timing but also exposes the treatment record whose date you altered.

Murderer route: You took the toxin sample from the conservation cabinet earlier. At 6:42, while carrying a condition-report folder to Sterling, you added it to his cordial and disposed of the stopper in your glove pouch.

Innocent evidence / Card A: LAB GLOVE - Rafael's glove carries several conservation chemicals, and his access key fits the cabinet from which the toxin sample disappeared. He says both facts are ordinary parts of his job.

Murderer evidence / Card B: LAB GLOVE - The stopper from the missing toxin vial was found inside Rafael's glove pouch. Rafael claimed he had not handled that vial in months.

06 / Imogen Muse

Victim relationship: Sterling appropriated the concept for one of your unreleased performances and planned to unveil a sanitized version of it as the gala's closing spectacle, crediting himself as creative patron.

Hidden complication: You wrote and planted the ominous anonymous warning note about 'returning what was taken.' It was meant as an art-world provocation, not a literal threat. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act

II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You entered the Donor Salon earlier to leave a small silver performance prop. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Media Room printer log shows you producing revised copies of the anonymous 'return what was taken' note you planted as part of your provocation. The print history clears your timing but reveals that the creepy warning was yours.

Murderer route: At 6:45 you carried a silver prop into the Donor Salon as cover. You used it to stir the toxin into Sterling's cordial, wiped it, and returned to Avery only moments later.

Innocent evidence / Card B: SILVER PROP - A silver pick from Imogen's installation was found near the Donor Salon entrance. Imogen admits bringing the prop through that area earlier in the evening.

Murderer evidence / Card A: SILVER PROP - The silver pick from Imogen's installation carries a trace matching Sterling's poisoned cordial. Imogen said the prop never left the Grand Gallery.

07 / Julian Brush

Victim relationship: Sterling owned an embarrassing student painting you have spent years trying to buy back. He planned to display it tonight beside your celebrated recent work as a joke about 'humble beginnings.'

Hidden complication: You have secretly used buyers to acquire several of your own early paintings so you could remove them from circulation. The art world would find that both vain and market-manipulative. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Cobalt pigment from your jacket appears on the drink tray because you signed a catalogue there earlier. During the poison window, the Registrar's copier records you scanning proxy-purchase paperwork connected to your secret campaign to buy back your own early paintings. The log clears your timing but exposes the buybacks.

Murderer route: At 6:44 you entered with a signed sketch for Sterling. You poisoned the cordial and wiped the glass, but a fleck of your distinctive cobalt studio pigment transferred from your cuff to the stem.

Innocent evidence / Card A: COBALT TRACE - Julian's distinctive cobalt pigment appears on the service tray cloth. Julian says he transferred it earlier while signing a catalogue nearby.

Murderer evidence / Card B: COBALT TRACE - A fleck of Julian's distinctive studio cobalt is embedded in the wiped stem of Sterling's glass. Julian claimed he never went near the private service.

08 / Helena Cross

Victim relationship: You wrote a private legal memorandum concluding that the Star Bowl's acquisition was too risky to defend confidently. Sterling forced you to replace it with a softer opinion and planned to cite your name during the announcement.

Hidden complication: Both versions of the memo still exist. You kept the original instead of destroying it, which could expose you to professional embarrassment and Sterling to serious scrutiny. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: A torn corner of your legal pad was found in the salon from your 6:28 meeting with Sterling. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Registrar's secure printer and fax log show you reproducing and transmitting the harsher original legal memo you had been pressured to soften. The record clears your timing but exposes both versions.

Murderer route: At 6:46 you returned with the original memo and demanded Sterling change his announcement. When he refused, you poisoned his cordial. A torn corner from your pad remained beneath the decanter.

Innocent evidence / Card A: LEGAL PAD - A torn corner from Helena's legal pad was found beside Sterling's service. Helena acknowledges a private meeting earlier in the evening but denies returning later.

Murderer evidence / Card B: LEGAL PAD - The torn paper beneath Sterling's decanter matches Helena's pad and bears the indented words '6:46 - final chance.' Helena denied a second meeting.

09 / Dr. Marcus Pryce

Victim relationship: Sterling suppressed your research showing that two objects in his collection passed through a dealer linked to questionable wartime sales. He threatened to release correspondence suggesting you had overstated another provenance claim if you challenged him publicly.

Hidden complication: One celebrated article of yours does contain an inference you stated too confidently. The main thesis still stands, but the mistake would be humiliating. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: A black-star archive seal from your research packet was found in the Donor Salon. During the poison window, the Media Room archive scanner records you copying correspondence related to the weak inference in your celebrated article. The scan sequence clears your timing but exposes the scholarly mistake Sterling was using against you.

Murderer route: At 6:43 you carried a research packet to Sterling. You poisoned the cordial after he refused to release the acquisition files. One black-star seal from your packet adhered beneath the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card B: ARCHIVE SEAL - One of Marcus's distinctive black-star paper seals was found on the Donor Salon floor. Marcus says several came loose from his research packet during Act I.

Murderer evidence / Card A: ARCHIVE SEAL - A black-star seal from Marcus's private research packet is stuck to the underside of Sterling's drink tray. Marcus said the packet never entered the salon.

10 / Sienna Voss

Victim relationship: Sterling told you he intended to rewrite the family trust tonight, removing you from control of the charitable foundation unless you publicly backed his museum naming plan.

Hidden complication: You have been quietly organizing other family trustees to block Sterling's control over the foundation and redirect future giving toward worker and community programs. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You confronted Sterling privately at 6:30 and left angry. From 6:40 to 6:49, the donor-office scanner records you copying the draft trust documents you intended to use against him with the other trustees. The scan log clears your timing but exposes the family challenge.

Murderer route: You returned at 6:45 after learning the trust papers were ready. During the argument you slipped the toxin directly into Sterling's silver coupe and scratched its base with your signet ring while steadying it.

Innocent evidence / Card A: SILVER COUPE SCRATCH - A crescent scratch on the base of Sterling's silver coupe resembles the edge of Sienna's signet ring. Sienna insists the mark predates her private argument with Sterling.

Murderer evidence / Card B: SILVER COUPE SCRATCH - A fresh crescent scratch on the base of Sterling's silver coupe exactly matches Sienna's signet ring. An earlier setup photograph shows no mark.

11 / Everett Locke

Victim relationship: Sterling ordered you to disable the Donor Salon camera because he planned several off-the-record meetings. He then told you that if anything went wrong tonight, security would 'own the failure.'

Hidden complication: You personally unplugged the camera despite museum policy. You did it under direct donor pressure and never documented the order. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect

it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Your master key opened the salon at 6:29 when you disabled the camera. During the poison window, the main security panel records manual system checks under your code every ninety seconds from a console physically located in the security station. The log clears your timing but also proves you violated policy by disabling the camera.

Murderer route: You used your master key at 6:46 to re-enter the camera-blind salon. Furious that Sterling planned to blame you for any problem, you poisoned his cordial and relied on the missing footage to protect you.

Innocent evidence / Card B: CAMERA SHUTDOWN - Everett's master key opened the Donor Salon at 6:29, when the security camera was intentionally disabled. Everett admits doing it but says Sterling ordered the shutdown.

Murderer evidence / Card A: MASTER KEY LOG - Everett's master key opened the Donor Salon at 6:46, seventeen minutes after the camera was disabled. Everett denied re-entering.

12 / Nadia Quill

Victim relationship: You were preparing a major investigation into Sterling's collection and labor empire. He discovered enough to threaten an injunction and promised to reveal the identity of one of your confidential museum sources if you published.

Hidden complication: You obtained internal documents through a source inside the Meridian. Protecting that source matters more to you than tonight's scoop. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You slipped into the Donor Salon at 6:31 hoping to interview Sterling and left when he refused. From 6:40 to 6:49, the Press Room scanner records you copying the confidential source documents

behind your embargoed story. The scan log clears your timing but risks exposing how much internal material you possess.

Murderer route: At 6:47 you returned after Sterling threatened your source. You poisoned his cordial and then wrote a false earlier timestamp in your notebook to create distance from the salon.

Innocent evidence / Card A: REPORTER'S NOTEBOOK - A page covering roughly the poisoning window has been torn from Nadia's notebook. Nadia admits she tried to get a private interview with Sterling earlier.

Murderer evidence / Card B: REPORTER'S NOTES - The ink and page order show Nadia inserted the 6:41-6:50 'Leo interview' timestamp after later notes. Leo remembers speaking with her earlier, not then.

13 / Lucian Gable

Victim relationship: Sterling demanded a dangerous last-minute change to the centerpiece display and threatened to withhold your firm's final payment if you refused. He also planned to blame you publicly for any flaw in the opening-night presentation.

Hidden complication: You signed off on one temporary lighting rig that did not fully meet your own design standard because there was no time to rebuild it before the gala. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Your brass screwdriver was found near the salon after circulating through installation work. During the poison window, the centerpiece lighting console records continuous manual adjustments under your designer code from the Grand Gallery. The console log clears your timing but exposes the unapproved temporary rig you signed off on.

Murderer route: At 6:45 you used a lighting check as cover to enter the salon. You poisoned Sterling's cordial and accidentally left your distinctive brass screwdriver near the service tray.

Innocent evidence / Card B: BRASS SCREWDRIVER - Lucian's distinctive screwdriver was found near the Donor Salon service table. Calvin says he borrowed it during installation but cannot remember exactly when he returned it.

Murderer evidence / Card A: BRASS SCREWDRIVER - Lucian's distinctive screwdriver was found beneath Sterling's service table with a fresh smear matching the wiped glass stem. Lucian claimed it never left his toolkit.

14 / Vivienne Marrow

Victim relationship: Sterling intended to announce that the Star Bowl would become a permanent Meridian holding, undermining months of quiet restitution negotiations and publicly humiliating the international partners you represent.

Hidden complication: You leaked the existence of the restitution talks to selected journalists to pressure Sterling, even though the negotiations were supposed to remain confidential. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You delivered a formal letter to Sterling at 6:28. During the poison window, the Registrar's secure fax machine was transmitting your confidential restitution packet page by page under your authorization code. The transmission log clears your timing but exposes negotiations you were supposed to keep quiet.

Murderer route: At 6:46 you returned with a second envelope containing a final demand. When Sterling refused, you poisoned the cordial. You discarded the envelope after it picked up a drop from the drink.

Innocent evidence / Card A: EMBOSSED ENVELOPE - A diplomatic envelope delivered by Vivienne was found in the Donor Salon bin with a dark cordial stain. Vivienne says it came from an earlier meeting.

Murderer evidence / Card B: EMBOSSED ENVELOPE - A second diplomatic envelope from Vivienne, unknown to staff, was found in the salon bin with a fresh cordial stain. Vivienne denied returning after her first delivery.

15 / Theo Glass

Victim relationship: Sterling had blacklisted you from a major acquisition after you outbid him anonymously for a work he wanted. Tonight he planned to announce that your collecting practices were 'speculative theater' and block your appointment to the museum board.

Hidden complication: You were the anonymous buyer in the auction incident everyone keeps referencing. You concealed your identity through Grant to avoid a bidding war with Sterling. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Your cufflink did chip against the Grand Gallery rail. During the poison window, the collection scanner records you copying the auction invoice that proves you were the anonymous bidder who outbid Sterling. The scan sequence clears your timing but exposes the identity you hid through Grant.

Murderer route: At 6:44 you slipped into the Donor Salon to force a reconciliation before the announcement. You poisoned the cordial when Sterling refused. Your glass cufflink struck the service table and chipped; one fragment remained on the carpet.

Innocent evidence / Card B: GLASS FRAGMENT - A chip matching Theo's distinctive cufflink was found near the threshold between the Grand Gallery and Donor Salon. Theo says the cufflink broke against the gallery rail.

Murderer evidence / Card A: GLASS FRAGMENT - A chip matching Theo's distinctive glass cufflink was found beneath Sterling's service table. Theo said he never entered the Donor Salon.

16 / Beatrice Plinth

Victim relationship: Sterling planned to reveal that you accepted his first questionable donation in 1989 despite incomplete paperwork, staining the legacy you built.

Hidden complication: You did approve that accession because the museum was desperate for funds and you convinced yourself the paperwork would follow. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You were in the Grand Gallery telling Leo the story of the museum's founding during the key window; three people heard you.

Murderer route: At 6:45 you returned to the salon with your old accession notebook and poisoned his cordial after he threatened to make you the sole scapegoat.

Innocent evidence / Card A: FOUNDING TIMELINE - Adrian and Leo both place Beatrice in the Grand Gallery telling museum stories from 6:41 through 6:50.

Murderer evidence / Card B: OLD ACCESSION PAGE - A page torn from Beatrice's 1989 accession notebook was found under Sterling's service tray with a fresh cordial stain.

17 / Conrad Gavel

Victim relationship: Sterling threatened to expose a private sale you arranged outside your auction house's normal process unless you waived a substantial fee.

Hidden complication: You did route the sale through a discreet subsidiary to satisfy a client who insisted on anonymity. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: You were loudly arguing with Grant about buyer premiums during the critical minutes, witnessed by Daphne.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:44 with a valuation sheet, poisoned the cordial, and left the auction pencil you used to stir it.

Innocent evidence / Card B: AUCTION FLOOR WITNESS - Grant and Daphne both remember Conrad loudly disputing buyer premiums in the Grand Gallery throughout the crucial minutes.

Murderer evidence / Card A: AUCTION PENCIL - Conrad's distinctive red auction pencil was found beside Sterling's glass with a trace of the poisoned cordial on its lacquer.

18 / Lola Loom

Victim relationship: Sterling intended to purchase a family-owned ceremonial textile you had borrowed for your installation, despite your refusal to sell.

Hidden complication: The textile is in the exhibition without the full paperwork your family expected because you were afraid the loan would be denied. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Avery photographed you repairing a hanging thread in the gallery continuously through the key window.

Murderer route: You brought a textile swatch to Sterling at 6:46, poisoned his drink, and left a distinctive thread on the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card A: INSTALLATION WITNESS - Julian and Imogen both place Lola repairing a textile in the Grand Gallery during the poisoning window.

Murderer evidence / Card B: INDIGO THREAD - A distinctive hand-dyed indigo fiber from Lola's sleeve was caught in the wiped stem of Sterling's glass.

19 / Sebastian Reed

Victim relationship: You found an archival document that contradicted the Star Bowl label. Sterling told your department your fellowship could disappear if you pushed it.

Hidden complication: You have not yet told Marcus that your discovery also undermines one sentence in his published research. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Celeste was reviewing the disputed label with you during the entire critical window.

Murderer route: You used your student access badge to enter at 6:47, poisoned the cordial, and dropped an archival tab from your notes.

Innocent evidence / Card B: LABEL REVIEW - Celeste's annotated proof shows Sebastian working beside her on the disputed label from 6:40 through 6:49.

Murderer evidence / Card A: ARCHIVAL TAB - One of Sebastian's numbered archival tabs was found adhered beneath Sterling's drink tray. The number corresponds to the document Sterling ordered suppressed.

20 / Malcolm Carrara

Victim relationship: Sterling planned to replace your commissioned entrance sculpture with a cheaper replica after the opening and dispute your final payment.

Hidden complication: You built one internal support differently from the approved plan because the fabricator missed a deadline. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Calvin and Lucian were with you moving a pedestal during the key window.

Murderer route: You entered the salon at 6:43 to demand payment, poisoned the cordial, and left marble dust from your cuff on the service cloth.

Innocent evidence / Card A: INSTALLATION CREW - Lucian places Malcolm beside him moving a pedestal during the poisoning window, and the move is logged on Calvin's handling sheet.

Murderer evidence / Card B: MARBLE DUST - Fresh Carrara dust matching Malcolm's studio sample was found on the wiped stem of Sterling's glass, not elsewhere on the service.

21 / Daphne Palette

Victim relationship: Sterling knew you quietly sold a work you had publicly promised to donate to another institution and planned to expose the contradiction.

Hidden complication: You sold it to cover a failed business investment and hoped to replace it before anyone noticed. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Theo and Grant were both with you discussing an auction lot during the key window.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:45 with a gift pledge, poisoned the drink, and left lipstick on the decanter stopper.

Innocent evidence / Card B: AUCTION CHAT - Theo and Grant both place Daphne with them discussing a forthcoming lot throughout the key minutes.

Murderer evidence / Card A: DECANter STOPPER - A cosmetic trace matching Daphne's distinctive gala lipstick was found beneath the lip of Sterling's decanter stopper, not on any shared glassware.

22 / Morgan Slate

Victim relationship: Sterling discovered that you write an anonymous satirical newsletter skewering museum patrons and planned to unmask you during his speech.

Hidden complication: Several jokes in the newsletter came from private conversations, and you regret at least one of them. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Nadia was arguing with you in the dining room throughout the critical minutes.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:44 to beg him not to expose you, poisoned the cordial, and left a torn draft joke in the bin.

Innocent evidence / Card A: CRITIC'S ARGUMENT - Nadia confirms Morgan was in the dining room debating them from 6:40 until nearly 6:50.

Murderer evidence / Card B: TORN DRAFT - A scrap from Morgan's anonymous satirical newsletter was found in the salon bin. On the back is a handwritten note: '6:44 - make him stop.'

23 / Felix Savoy

Victim relationship: Sterling had refused to approve the final catering invoice and planned to blame you for a last-minute service change he personally ordered.

Hidden complication: You changed his private beverage setup twice because Sterling and his assistant gave contradictory instructions. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Multiple staff and Riley place you at the buffet line during the critical minutes.

Murderer route: You were alone with the service tray at 6:46 and poisoned the cordial before sending it to the salon.

Innocent evidence / Card B: SERVICE LOG - Margot and two servers place Felix continuously at the buffet line from 6:40 through 6:50; the private cordial had already left his station.

Murderer evidence / Card A: SERVICE ROUTE CARD - Felix's own route card records a private return to the Donor Salon at 6:46, although he told investigators the cordial left his hands before 6:40.

24 / Calvin Case

Victim relationship: Sterling saw you damage a minor frame during installation and threatened to have you fired after the gala, despite the damage being repairable.

Hidden complication: You concealed the crack with a reversible mount until Rafael could inspect it after opening night. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Rafael was with you adjusting a mount throughout the critical window.

Murderer route: You used the service corridor at 6:45, poisoned the cordial, and dropped a crate-seal tab beneath the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card A: CONSERVATION WORK - Rafael confirms Calvin was with him adjusting a mount throughout the poisoning window.

Murderer evidence / Card B: CRATE-SEAL TAB - A numbered Northstar crate-seal tab from Calvin's handling pouch was found beneath Sterling's service tray.

25 / Maya Bell

Victim relationship: Sterling's gift conditions would cut public education programming to fund a private donor lounge and VIP entrance.

Hidden complication: You organized an anonymous staff petition against the plan and slipped copies into trustee folders. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Adrian and Riley both place you in the Grand Gallery during the key minutes.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:47 to leave the petition, poisoned the cordial, and left a docent pin by the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card B: GALLERY WITNESS - Adrian places Maya in the Grand Gallery discussing the education budget during the crucial minutes.

Murderer evidence / Card A: DOCENT PIN - Maya's distinctive enamel docent pin was found behind Sterling's service table. Maya said she never entered the Donor Salon.

26 / Avery Lens

Victim relationship: Sterling ordered you to surrender a photograph showing him meeting privately with Grant beside a shell-company shipping file.

Hidden complication: You kept a backup print after agreeing to delete the image from your camera. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Your continuous photo sequence shows you shooting Imogen in the gallery during the key window.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:44 to negotiate, poisoned the cordial, and left a torn photo corner by the service table.

Innocent evidence / Card A: PHOTO SEQUENCE - Avery's camera sequence timestamps Imogen in the Grand Gallery continuously through the poisoning window; Avery had to be behind the camera for the series.

Murderer evidence / Card B: TORN PRINT - A corner torn from Avery's hidden backup photograph was found beside Sterling's service with a fresh cordial stain across the emulsion.

27 / Juno March

Victim relationship: Sterling had you removed from a previous museum event and threatened legal action if you disrupted tonight's unveiling.

Hidden complication: You planted small 'PROVENANCE IS A VERB' stickers in several gallery brochures for a peaceful protest. Do not volunteer this

immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Marcus was debating you in public during the entire critical window.

Murderer route: You slipped into the salon at 6:45, poisoned the cordial, and left adhesive backing from one of your stickers.

Innocent evidence / Card B: PUBLIC DEBATE - Marcus confirms Juno was arguing restitution policy with him in full view throughout the poisoning window.

Murderer evidence / Card A: STICKER BACKING - Adhesive backing from one of Juno's hidden protest stickers was found under Sterling's glass tray with a trace of the poisoned cordial.

28 / Penny Varnish

Victim relationship: One decorative object in the exhibition once belonged to your family. You believe Sterling acquired it through a manipulative private sale decades ago.

Hidden complication: You brought old correspondence proving your family contested that sale and planned to confront him tonight. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Beatrice and Conrad were with you discussing the old sale during the key window.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:43, poisoned the cordial, and dropped one page of the old correspondence near the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card A: COLLECTOR'S ALIBI - Sienna and Theo both remember Penny examining the centerpiece with them from 6:41 through 6:49.

Murderer evidence / Card B: FAMILY LETTER - One page of Penny's decades-old ownership correspondence was found on Sterling's service table with a wet cordial ring across the signature.

29 / Leo Taggart

Victim relationship: Sterling fed you several flattering claims for an earlier profile that you later discovered were exaggerated. He threatened to cut off access if you corrected them.

Hidden complication: You are preparing a correction that will also make you look embarrassingly credulous. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Nadia's notes and Maya both place you in the dining room during the key minutes.

Murderer route: You entered at 6:46 for a quote, poisoned the cordial, and left your distinctive press pencil beneath the service table.

Innocent evidence / Card B: REPORTER'S CROSS-CHECK - Nadia's notebook contains details from a conversation with Leo during the poisoning window that only Leo could have supplied.

Murderer evidence / Card A: PRESS PENCIL - Leo's vintage Meridian-branded press pencil was found beneath Sterling's tray with cordial on the sharpened end.

30 / Riley Bloom

Victim relationship: Sterling ordered you to add a gaudy lighting cue to the unveiling and threatened to withhold payment when Lucian objected.

Hidden complication: You secretly changed the cue again after approval, causing the eerie light flickers guests noticed during Act I. Do not volunteer this immediately. In Act II, protect it unless interrogation forces your hand; in Act III, reveal it if you need to defend yourself.

Innocent route: Lucian was with you adjusting the centerpiece lighting through the critical window.

Murderer route: You entered the salon at 6:44 to retrieve a lighting remote, poisoned the cordial, and left a gold ribbon fiber on the tray.

Innocent evidence / Card A: LIGHTING LOG - Lucian's cue sheet and the control console both place Riley beside the centerpiece lights throughout the poisoning window.

Murderer evidence / Card B: GOLD RIBBON FIBER - A metallic gold ribbon fiber from Riley's gala styling kit was found caught in the wiped stem of Sterling's glass.

Difficulty & continuity

Every core suspect has a real motive and plausible opportunity before branching. The murderer gains one branch-specific contradiction or physical trace in Act III; innocent suspects gain a corroborated alibi or benign explanation. The killer should therefore rise above the field only for players who integrate motive, timing, and the late evidence rather than voting on motive alone. The fixed toxicology and camera clues deliberately do not narrow to a profession or a small subset.